board of moves and counter moves that seem to make inevitable the continued persecution and traumatisation of a valued colleague.'

In a gist, the letter said the ISRO espionage case had done immense damage to my morale, and revealed that India's space programme was no longer immune to outside interference; it could derail India's space programmes and adversely affect national interest.

The others who signed the statement were two former ISRO Chairman —Satish Dhawan and U R Rao, UGC Chairman Yash Pal, National Institute of Advanced Studies Director Roddam Narasimha and then IIM Professor S Chandrashekar, the father of Indian remote sensing. A year later, the Supreme Court acquitted all the accused in the ISRO spy case. The men who conspired to shatter my life and India's space dreams still await punishment.

If Seshan was so disciplined not to argue with his superiors like Dhawan, he was also a ruthless task master for his subordinates. And this he did with no agenda than conscientiousness, for he felt if someone was not doing his job, he doesn't deserve the job. For the accounts and administrative staff who faltered at work, Seshan was a terror. Once when I was in his office, Seshan summoned an accounts officer who had been sleeping on a file for long. The officer tentatively walked in and stood across Seshan's desk.

'Have you drawn your last month's salary, Hariharan?' Seshan said in a deceptively polite tone.

'Yes sir,' came the answer.

'Then go and deposit the money back in the ISRO account. You don't deserve that money.'

As the officer stood hanging his head, Seshan thundered: 'Go jump into the first agglomeration of water that you see.'

I had to look up the dictionary for 'agglomeration'. This man was as bombastic as he was original.